

Question 1

[20]

(Do not spend more than 30 minutes on this question.)

Write a composition (300 - 350 words) on **any one** of the following:

- (i) Write an original short story entitled 'A Strange Visitor'.
- (ii) Narrate an incident from your experience in which your parents had entrusted you with a difficult task. Give details of the task, how you carried it out and your feelings at the end.
- (iii) Describe how you spend your time on a holiday afternoon. Why do you think it is necessary to have these times of quietness and solitude?
- (iv) Express your views either for **or** against the statement 'Junk food should be banned'.
- (v) Study the picture given below. Write a story or a description or an account of what it suggests to you. Your composition may be about the subject of the picture, or you may take suggestions from it; however, there must be a clear connection between the picture and your composition.



Comments of Examiners

(i) Original Short Story: A strange visitor

A number of candidates attempted to write the short story; however, many of them did not pay attention to the key points. Most of the candidates did not highlight the 'strangeness' of the visitor or failed to understand the word 'strange' as something unusual or surprising or even unknown. The plot and characters were not well developed. Plot twists and dialogues were absent in most stories. The majority of the candidates mostly treated the topic like a narrative essay of a past experience as it did not contain the elements of story writing. A large number of candidates did not understand the meaning of the word 'original'.

(ii) Narrative Composition: Difficult task

The entire question was not answered till the end, especially the lesson learnt by majority of the candidates. The candidates were unable to understand the meaning of the word 'entrusted'. 'Feelings' at the end were mostly missing.

A large number of candidates who attempted narrative essay went beyond their 'plausible age'. The experiences described had more relevance to adult tasks such as office work. Sentence structure and language were found to be below the standard expected at this level.

(iii) Descriptive Composition: Holiday afternoon of quietness and solitude

A number of candidates described the entire day or holiday rather than an 'afternoon.'

'Quietness and solitude' were misunderstood or left out altogether.

Many candidates wrote about enjoyment with friends and relatives on a holiday afternoon.

(iv) Argumentative Composition: Junk food

The majority of the candidates took a stand against the topic but described the ill effects of 'Junk food' which appeared to be contradictory. Some candidates made the repetition of the same argument. Sometimes, a few candidates did not take a clear stand. Some candidates argued both sides of the question. The candidates wrote both

Suggestions for teachers

- Explain the 'format' of short story writing.
- In every story writing practice session, lay stress on the importance of writing an original story.
- Teach plot structure.
- Practise dialogue writing.
- Discuss how to build up a character.
- Give adequate practise of writing a logical ending through brainstorming sessions.
- Explain the difference between the short story and the first-person account.
- Show students the way to divide the topics into paragraphs.
- Inspire students' creativity by exploring the works of different short story authors.
- Explain the difference between short story and narrative writing.
- Teach mind mapping on any given topic and give practise in the class.
- Lay emphasis on understanding the question and making sure that each subpart of the question is answered clearly, without overlap.
- Encourage practise of writing first-person essays and narrating experiences of their present age.
- Provide practise of tenses and subject-verb agreement from lower classes.
- Give orals in the form of pick and speak, elocution, debate, etc.
- Teach students to:
 - include meaningful adjectives and adverbs to add depth to the description.
 - add vivid details. Specific details paint a picture in the reader's mind and appeal to the reader's senses.
 - use figurative language. Tools of the writer's craft such as analogy, simile, and metaphor add depth to authors' descriptions.

‘for’ and ‘against’ the topic. Irrelevant arguments or lack of illustrative examples were also written.

(v) **Picture Composition**

This sub-part of this question was not attempted by many of the candidates. Instead of ‘carrom’, a few candidates had written about ‘cricket’ or other games. Some candidates were unable to present their thoughts or frame sentences and hence, copied the comprehension entirely. Mere itemization was also observed. There was content-specific error was also noted. There was no clear connection between the composition and the picture.

Suggestions for teachers

- use precise language.
- think about how the five senses respond to the object to be described.
- do thoughtful organisation.
- Discuss how to start with an interesting anecdote or idea.
- Stress upon structure – to think of *three to four* main points and to build the arguments around these points, using examples to illustrate and strengthen. Advise to avoid repetition.
- Explain the importance of taking a strong stance – either ‘for’ or ‘against’ and give practise in writing the same.
- Train students how to conclude with an interesting idea or by summarising the argument or idea.
- Conduct debates in class to train the students to firmly state their view and take a clear stand.
- Teach students to use the picture just as a precursor to the story/ write up and to avoid mere itemization.
- Discuss what the picture suggests and thereby arrive at the concept or central idea.
- Share with discussion on the varied possibilities of approaching a picture composition – as an account, a narrative, a story or a description.
- Explain to students how to think of the picture as the title or topic of the essay followed by choosing the format.
- Structure the composition using the rules for essay writing as prescribed with the various formats.

MARKING SCHEME

Question 1

(i)	The story must be original and must have <u>at least two characters</u> – the narrator and the visitor. The ‘strangeness’ must be qualified, the encounter and the action that arises out of the encounter described. Credit to be given for humour or suspense. Accept a wide interpretation of visitor as in alien, animal or human.
(ii)	This is a first-person account and must be narrated from within the plausible experience of a Class X candidate. There must be a clear description of the difficult task and how it was carried out. The feeling of satisfaction, contentment and joy etc. must form the conclusion of the composition.
(iii)	This is a descriptive essay giving an account of quietness, rest, solitude or a leisure time activity that is done alone like reading, writing, listening to music. The candidate must describe the activity as well as the benefits of quietness and solitude. Any contradiction (e.g. noisy parties, crowds, sports) of solitude and quietness must be penalised.
(iv)	Views either for or against are to be accepted. The candidate should take a clear stand and give valid reasons for whatever stand he/she takes. Credit to be given for a cohesive well-constructed logical argument and ideas based on logical reasoning and personal experience.
(v)	Accept a wide interpretation. Any relevant ideas taken from the picture should be accepted. However, a <i>mere itemization / listing / description</i> of the picture is to be penalised.

Question 2

[10]

(Do not spend more than 20 minutes on this question.)

Select **any one** of the following:

- (i) Your friend was absent from school on a day when an unfortunate incident took place for which you were blamed. Write a letter to your friend giving details about the incident, your role in it and how the matter was finally resolved.
- (ii) You wish to stage a play to create awareness about the importance of saving electricity. Write a letter to the Manager of a nearby shopping mall/supermarket requesting permission to use the space in front of the shopping mall/supermarket to stage the play. Give him/her details about your requirements and state why the play will be beneficial to the shoppers.

Comments of Examiners

(i) (a) Informal letter

Content-specific errors

Many candidates had difficulty in understanding the question in its entirety, and emphasis was primarily on the two components i.e. 'the incident' and 'how they were blamed'. The 'proving of innocence' and/or 'their role' were not described by many candidates. The resolution of the incident was not mentioned by some of the candidates. Both aspects of the same questions were not understood in entirety. However, some candidates wrote about incidents that happened outside the school.

Format

A large number of candidates made errors in punctuation. Erroneous Spelling and capitalisation errors in spelling, for instance 'February' were made by many candidates. The date was incorrect, or the year was not given in the answers. Subscription and Salutation errors (Yours sincerely as subscription and ABC and XYZ used for signature) were made by most of the candidates. 'Dear friend' was used without mention of proper nouns. There were identified errors in the format.

Expression

The common errors made by many candidates were related to spelling, grammar, sentence structure etc.

(ii) Formal Letter

Format

Sender's address: incomplete address given by many of the candidates. Receiver's address - The name of Shopping mart was not written. In Date: Erroneous Spelling and Capitalisation error in spelling 'February' were noted. Subscription and Salutation: 'Respected Sir' to address, 'Yours sincerely' as subscription and 'ABC' and 'XYZ' used for signature were made by many candidates.

Suggestions for teachers

- Teach the correct format (address, date, salutation, and subscription) by referring to CISCE's website.
- Teach students to read the question carefully and to develop the 'points' adequately.
- Share with students the correct salutation and subscription including only first name to be used and appropriate tone in content.
- Conduct classroom activities to improve language, structure and expression. Emphasise on providing an appropriate tone to the content.
- Encourage reading and discussion to improve language dexterity.
- Explain in detail the key aspects of the letter like format, body and expression.
- Practise the formats thoroughly with the students.
- Highlight the importance of identifying key elements in a topic – the staging of the play, the key requirements, the benefits and so on.
- Explain the necessity of using precise language.
- Avoid use of flat faulty language, use of contractions, short forms, informal or colloquial language.
- Read out examples of good formal letters to give the students an understanding of how formal language may be employed effectively.
- Explain the difference between formal and informal language.

Content

Weightage was given to the ‘**benefits**’ of the play. Inadequate attention was given to ‘**requirements**’. Only ‘space’ was mentioned for a requirement by many candidates without specifics of the space while other requirements were not mentioned.

Expression

A number of candidates made the punctuation errors. Candidates did not understand what the word ‘requirements’ meant. Errors in spelling, grammar, syntax, sentence structure, paragraphing were identified. Moreover, informal language was used such as ‘we are kids’ by most of the candidates.

MARKING SCHEME**Question 2**

(i)

Format (Friendly/Informal letter)**Content**Details about the incident -

Includes description of a ‘normal’ event – where something goes wrong.

e.g. a game or classroom activity in or during which a prank is played, there is an accident, cheating, any act of misconduct or indiscipline. *(Any two)*

Your role in it -

e.g. assisted in the prank, you could be the ringleader, you accidentally or deliberately hurt somebody, copied or assisted in copying, bullying. *(Any two)*

How was the problem resolved -

e.g. confession, apology, will not do it again, learnt a lesson. *(Any one)*

Expression

Language, syntax and vocabulary.

(ii)

Format (Formal letter)**Content**

Request permission

e.g. Please may I, kindly grant etc.

Details about requirement

e.g. date, time, other arrangements like stage, electricity, microphones etc.

Why the play will be beneficial-

e.g. conservation of resources, overuse of fossil fuels, creating awareness of the need to conserve, etc.

Expression

Language, syntax and vocabulary.

Question 3

- (i) Your school is hosting an Inter School Dance Competition. Write a notice to be put up on your school notice board informing the students about the event. [5]
- (ii) Write an email to the Principal of a neighbouring school to request him/her to send their dance teacher to act as a judge for the competition. [5]

Comments of Examiners

(i) In writing the notice, the following errors were observed:

- The creative title was missing or words meant to describe or name the event were used for the title. Some titles had no relevance to the topic and others were too long.
- The date of the event was the same as the date of the examination and the year was not mentioned. Moreover, some candidates mentioned the date of the event that was too far ahead to be relevant when the date of the event should have been set around 10 to 14 days after the notice.
- The notice details were given in a paragraph. Many candidates did not adhere to the format. Date, time, and venue positions were interchanged at will. Details of time, date, and venue were incomplete. For example, the year was not mentioned in the date, the venue was not specific or just 'one part of the venue' was written instead of both.
- The date for registration was either too close to or even after the date of the event. Many candidates were not taught to write this by/before the date.

(ii) In writing the email, the following errors were observed:

- Incomplete email-ids were given with at least one of the three components such as the @ sign missing.
- Personal email ids were given.

Suggestions for teachers

- Advise the students to refer to the council website (www.cisce.org) for the correct format.
- Frame a list of activities as well as creative titles for the events in the class.
- Practice creative titles of two-three words and avoid including words from the topic meant to describe/name the event.
- Explain the difference between the creative title and event. Discuss the need for the 'special' name for the event.
- Elucidate the need of providing specific information like date, time and venue of the event.
- Tell the students that the date of the event should be at least 10 to 14 days after the notice. Point out why there should be a gap between the date of registration and the date of the event.
- Inform the students about the three components that are required in the sentence aimed at the target group.
- Explain the differentiate between personal and official email id.
- Tell the students to copy the event of the notice as subject in email.
- Ask the students that the opening sentence must be in the first paragraph.
- Lay emphasis that notices & emails are interconnected so the date, time & venue in both must correspond.
- Explain to the students, the necessity for a polite closing of the mail.
- website when in doubt.

- Subject was not written. In subject – ‘Dance competition’ was missing in some papers.
- The opening sentence was not clear and did not touch upon the topic.
- The closing sentence was missing in many candidates. Some of the candidates made the opening and closing sentences overlap with the content. The closing sentence contained the invitation.
- Salutation and subscription: many candidates wrote ‘Respected sir/ Ma'am’ which was an incorrect salutation or just ‘thank you’ and the name as a subscription.
- A few of the candidates did not mention the date, venue and time. The date of the examination was written instead in the body of the mail. In some letters, the notice and email dates did not match.

Suggestions for teachers

- Train students to write salutation and subscription as written in the formal letter.
- Ask the students to refer to the Council website when in doubt.

(iii) Many candidates assumed the identity of the principal when issuing the invitation.

MARKING SCHEME

Question 3

(i)	Creative Title – e.g. Rhythmic Beats, Twinkletoes, Happy Feet Event: Inter School Dance Competition Date: Accept single date for example a week or fortnight away from the date of writing. Time: e.g. 10.00 a.m. – 3.00 p.m. Venue: smaller place to larger Participation: All pupils who wish to register should give their names to the Vice Principal/etc on or before...
(ii)	E-mail – id Subject Salutation Opening sentence Closing sentence Subscription Expression – All details of the notice are to be included in the e-mail.

Question 4

Read the following passage carefully and answer the questions that follow:

Ashamanja Babu lived in a small flat in Bhowanipore. A clerk in the registry department of Lajpat Rai Post Office, Ashamanja Babu was fortunate as he could walk to his office in seven minutes flat without having to fight his way into the buses and trains of Calcutta. He lived a rather carefree life as he was not the kind of person to sit and brood about what might have been had Fate been kinder to him. On the whole, he was quite content with his lot. Two Hindi films and fish twice a week – these were enough to keep him happy. The only thing that *perturbed* him at times was his lack of companionship. A bachelor with few friends and relatives, he often wished he had a dog to keep him company. It need not be a huge Alsatian like the one owned by the Talukdars, who lived two houses down the lane; it could be any ordinary little dog which would follow him around morning and evening, wag its tail when he came home from work and obey his orders faithfully. Ashamanja Babu's secret desires were that he would speak to his dog in English. 'Stand up', 'Sit down', 'Shake hands' – how nice it would be if his dog obeyed such commands! That would make him really happy.

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On a cloudy day marked by a steady drizzle, Ashamanja Babu went to the market in Hashimara to buy some oranges. At one end of the market, beside a *stunted* kul tree, sat a man. As their eyes met, the man smiled. Was he a beggar? His clothes made him look like one. Ashamanja Babu noticed at least five sewn-on patches on his trousers and jacket. But the man didn't have a begging bowl. Instead, by his side was a shoe-box with a little pup sticking its head out of it.

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'Good morning!' said the man in English. Ashamanja Babu was obliged to return the greeting.

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'Buy dog? Dog buy? Very good dog.' The man had taken the pup out of the box and had put it down on the ground. 'Very cheap. Very good. Happy dog.'

The pup shook the raindrops off its coat, looked at Ashamanja Babu and wagged its minuscule two-inch tail. Ashamanja Babu moved closer to the pup, crouched on the ground and stretched out his hand. The pup gave his ring finger a lick with its pink tongue. Nice, friendly dog.

'How much? What price?'

'Ten rupees.'

A little haggling and the price came down to seven rupees. Ashamanja Babu paid the money, put the pup back in the shoe-box, closed the lid to save it from the drizzle, and turned homewards, forgetting all about the oranges.

-Ashamanja Babu's Dog by Satyajit Ray

- (i) For each word given below choose the correct meaning (as used in the passage) from the options provided: [2]
1. perturbed (*line 8*)
 - (a) frightened
 - (b) unsettled
 - (c) confused
 - (d) mocked
 2. stunted (*line 19*)
 - (a) prevented from growing
 - (b) prepared for tricks
 - (c) prevented from taking action
 - (d) allowed to do stunts
- (ii) Which word in the passage means the opposite of the word ‘expensive’? [1]
- (a) carefree
 - (b) ordinary
 - (c) cheap
 - (d) haggling
- (iii) Answer the following questions briefly in your own words:
- (a) What kept Ashamanja Babu happy? [2]
 - (b) What does this tell you about him? [2]
 - (c) What is that one other thing he needed to complete his happiness? [1]
 - (d) Why did Ashamanja Babu think the man was a beggar? [2]
 - (e) Why did Ashamanja Babu forget about his oranges? [2]
- (iv) In not more than 50 words, narrate the series of events from the time the puppy was taken out of the box till it was paid for. [8]

Comments of Examiners

(i) 1. Vocabulary:

Majority of the candidates made many errors while attempting this part of the question. Some candidates wrote the incorrect letter against the answer and vice-versa. However, other candidates did not attempt all three answers. Contextual meaning was not understood. Some candidates wrote the incorrect meaning 'mocked'. Many candidates were found to be confused and opted the option (c). Some candidates wrote all the options and in some other responses, 'Perturbed' was mistaken for 'frightened'.

2. Many candidates chose the incorrect meaning i.e. 'prevented from taking action'. Some candidates mentioned all the options.

(ii) A large number of candidates made errors in this question. A few candidates chose option (b). Some candidates wrote all the options. Several candidates wrote the word 'carefree' instead of 'cheap'. Many candidates did not even notice the word '**opposite** of the word'. Candidates mentioned about 'his house' / 'his work' and 'his character'.

(iii) (a) Most of the candidates could not attempt this question properly. Some candidates could not write the proper answer with all four points. Candidates were unable to write the proper sentence. Some candidates copied the entire paragraph.

(b) Candidates could not identify the key answers from the paragraph. Some candidates were able to provide only a few points correctly. The same answer was repeated for all the questions by some of the candidates.

(c) Several candidates wrote companion/ companionship/pet instead of 'dog'.

(d) Most of the candidates either missed the word '**clothes**' or answered in a general paragraph rather than making a specific

Suggestions for teachers

- Provide rigorous practise of dictionary work, spelling and word games, usage of words in sentences, homonyms and synonyms.
- Teach students more word meanings through interesting and thought-provoking exercises in vocabulary.
- Clarify the usage of optional alphabets and the answers.
- Advise students not to choose all the optional answers and choose only one answer.
- Train students to read the questions carefully and how to interpret questions correctly.
- Encourage students to refer to the dictionary for word meanings.
- Make students understand the demand of the question by teaching understanding with reference.
- Encourage students to identify the keywords in the passage and use these keywords to answer relevant questions.
- Make students appreciate the creativity for the right construction.
- Help students to recognise their key answers according to their questions.
- Advise students against repeating the answers and paragraphs.
- Train students to use their own words rather than copying from the passage.
- Teach students to look for inferred meanings through analysis.
- Instruct the students to read the question carefully and then choose the right word or words to convey the meaning.
- Tell the students how to choose the sentence which conveys the correct meaning.
- Advise students to read the passage with understanding.
- Discuss with the students how to identify the cause and its effect.

mention of clothes and their patched condition.

- (e) Precis question had repetitive points. Most of the candidates simply copied words from the passage. Critical thinking was not seen in the responses.
- (iv) Many candidates were unable to answer this part appropriately. Several candidates did not keep to the word limit. They used more than 50 words to write the précis. Many candidates left out articles to reduce the word count. Some candidates wrote a summary of the entire comprehension passage/ part of the passage. Grids were often not drawn and rough summaries were not made. Word count was not given. Long-winded phrases and sentences were used where shorter, more precise wording would have been more effective. Some candidates were able to identify and write only *two* to *three* points. Some candidates did not follow the chronological order. However, some marks were lost for expression.

Suggestions for teachers

- Ask the students to read the extract carefully and answer the questions with reference to context.
- Train students to identify the key points from the passage.
- Instruct them not to cross the word limit that is 50 words.
- Advise them to frame correct sentences without ignoring articles and prepositions.
- Discuss with the students how to leave out irrelevant details.
- Explain to the students how to follow the sequence of events as mentioned in the passage.
- Ask students to find words or ideas that stand out - around which ideas have been built. Tell the students to incorporate these identified words as main points into the summary.

MARKING SCHEME

Question 4

(i)	1. (b) unsettled 2. (a) prevented from growing
(ii)	(c) cheap
(iii)	(a) Two Hindi films and fish twice a week. (b) content, happy, satisfied, at peace with himself, and not overly ambitious. (c) dog (d) clothes, five sewn-on patches on trousers and jacket. (e) so happy with the dog/got what he wanted/overjoyed – the oranges seemed trivial/unimportant.
(iv)	<u>Points:</u> 1. took out/put down (or both separately). 2. offered as a cheap/happy/good dog.

3. pup shook off raindrops.
4. looked at Ashamanja Babu.
5. wagged its tail.
6. Ashamanju Babu moved closer.
7. Ashamanju Babu crouched on the ground.
8. stretched out his hand.
9. puppy licked his finger.
10. Ashamanju Babu haggled.
11. brought down the price/ 10 to 7 rupees.
12. paid the money.
13. put pup in shoebox.

(Accept any six points and implied meaning.)

Question 5

- (i) Fill in each of the numbered blanks with the correct form of the word given in brackets. Do not copy the passage but write in correct serial order the word or phrase appropriate to the blank space. [4]

Example:

Next day my uncle (0) _____ (spend) a lot of time.

Answer: (0) spent

He (1) _____ (select) clothes for me, and my aunt (2) _____ (give) my face a scrub and (3) _____ (groom) me. My uncle (4) _____ (follow) me about (5) _____ (utter) several pieces of advice before (6) _____ (let) me out. 'You must never scowl even if the sun (7) _____ (hit) you in the eyes. You must try (8) _____ (look) pleasant.'

- (ii) Fill in the blanks with appropriate words. [4]
- (a) There's a black cat sitting _____ the wall.
 - (b) The horse jumped _____ the hedge.
 - (c) Mother goes _____ the market every day.

- (d) Several people have climbed Mount Everest _____ recent years.
- (e) I often go to school _____ my friend.
- (f) I have left my keys _____ home.
- (g) Instead of talking, prove your worth _____ doing something.
- (h) I have not slept _____ yesterday.

(iii) Choose the correct option to make one complete sentence **without using and, but or so**. [4]

1. The magician took pity on the mouse. He turned it into a cat.
 - (a) Showing pity on the mouse he turned it into a cat.
 - (b) Taking pity on the mouse he turned it into a cat.
 - (c) The magician turned the mouse into a cat by taking pity.
 - (d) Taking pity on the mouse the magician turned it into a cat.
2. This work must be completed. There is a deadline.
 - (a) Since this work must be completed, there is a deadline.
 - (b) This work must be completed because there is a deadline.
 - (c) This work must be completed though there is a deadline.
 - (d) This work must be completed when there is a deadline.
3. He fled somewhere. His pursuers could not follow him.
 - (a) He fled where his pursuers could not follow him.
 - (b) He pursued somewhere his followers could not flee.
 - (c) He fled somewhere when his pursuers could not follow him.
 - (d) He fled where his pursuers cannot follow him.
4. He began late. He finished first.
 - (a) He finished first and began late.
 - (b) He began first but finished late.
 - (c) Though he finished late, he began first.
 - (d) Though he began late, he finished first.

- (iv) Choose the correct option and rewrite the sentence according to the instruction given after each. [8]

1. Arun and Nikhil had climbed the mountain.

(Add a question tag)

- (a) Arun and Nikhil had climbed the mountain, didn't they?
- (b) Arun and Nikhil had climbed the mountain, had they?
- (c) Arun and Nikhil had climbed the mountain, hadn't they?
- (d) Arun and Nikhil had climbed the mountain, did they?

2. The children have broken the window pane.

(Begin: The window pane.....)

- (a) The window pane had been broken by the children.
- (b) The window pane has been broken by the children.
- (c) The window pane has not been broken by the children.
- (d) The window pane had not been broken by the children.

3. The apples are so cheap that they cannot be good.

(Use: 'too')

- (a) The apples are too cheap and good.
- (b) The apples are too cheap as well as good.
- (c) The apples are too good to be cheap.
- (d) The apples are too cheap to be good.

4. She is very clever and beautiful.

(Use: 'not only')

- (a) Not only is she very clever but also beautiful.
- (b) Not only was she beautiful and she was also clever.
- (c) Not only is she clever she was also very beautiful.
- (d) Not only was she very beautiful but is also clever.

5. I prefer a simple vanilla ice cream to fancy desserts.
(Begin: *I would rather.....*)
- (a) I would rather have a simple vanilla ice cream to fancy desserts.
 - (b) I would rather have a simple vanilla ice cream than fancy desserts.
 - (c) I would rather prefer a simple vanilla ice cream than fancy desserts.
 - (d) I would rather have a vanilla ice cream than a fancy dessert.
6. He asked, "When do you intend to make the payment?"
(Begin: *He asked*)
- (a) He asked when he did intend to make the payment.
 - (b) He asked when she is intending to make the payment.
 - (c) He asked when I intended to make the payment.
 - (d) He asked when they are intending to make the payment.
7. If the rain does not stop, Mariam will not be able to do the laundry.
(Begin: *Unless....*)
- (a) Unless the rain does not stop, Mariam will not be able to do the laundry.
 - (b) Unless Mariam does the laundry, the rain will not stop.
 - (c) Unless the rain stop, Mariam will not be able to do the laundry.
 - (d) Unless the rain stops, Mariam will not be able to do the laundry.
8. This is the best movie I have ever seen.
(Begin: *Never....*)
- (a) Never had I seen a good movie than this.
 - (b) Never I have seen a better movie than this.
 - (c) Never have I seen a better movie than this.
 - (d) I have never seen a good movie as this.

Comments of Examiners

(i) A number of candidates did not perform well in this part of the question. Some of the commonly occurring errors were as follows:

1. selects /select/and spelling errors as in 'selets'.
2. give/gaves
3. grooms/ gromed
4. follows
5. utters
6. lets
7. heats/hit/hites
8. looking

However, some candidates provided two optional answers.

(ii) The majority of the candidates made the following errors:

- a. beside
- b. across
- c. for
- d. over
- e. for
- f. in
- g. after
- h. from

However, a few candidates wrote more than one answer.

(iii)(1) Many candidates attempted this part erroneously. The option letter did not match with the corresponding statement. A few candidates resorted to shortcuts as they did not write complete sentences and were found to be confused between options (b) and (d). A few candidates could not join their sentences correctly.

(2) Many candidates chose incorrect response i.e. option (a). However, a few candidates did not use the word 'because' and used 'though' or 'since' instead.

Suggestions for teachers

- Explain how to use tenses in their various habitats and how changes in tense occur.
- Use a table to help the students visualise and understand the 'path' and conversion easily.
- Conduct spelling tests frequently.
- Teach students to read and understand the given passage in its entirety before selecting/deciding on answers.
- Provide exposure to adverbs and phrasal verbs in class.
- Give regular practise for usage of prepositions.
- Encourage reading and discussion in the class.
- Explain the importance of reading the entire sentence before deciding upon the preposition.
- Instruct the students to write only one option for each question.
- Instruct the students to write the option letter to match with the corresponding statement.
- Teach students to identify the distractors and then omit wrong choices accordingly. Advise them to ensure the meaning is not changed when choosing the correct option.
- Discuss with students when to use 'since' or 'though' or even 'when' and when to use 'because'.
- Teach students to follow the rules of grammar and to check the differences in the various options. They must understand when the 'somewhere' will change into the more definitive 'where' and that the action happened in the past.
- Tell the students that two clauses are made mutually exclusive by the use of the subordinating conjunction 'though', 'although' etc. and not exclusively inter-dependent as in a causal sentence. Build conceptual understanding among students through rigorous practise.

- (3) A large number of candidates mentioned the present tense 'cannot' instead of the past tense 'could not'.
- (4) Several candidates opted for the answer (c) instead of (d).
- (iv) (1) Instead of option (c), the candidates opted for option (a).
- (2) Many candidates ignored the present tense (have broken) and while answering opted the option (a) that had a past tense 'had been'.
- (3) Most of the candidates attempted this question correctly. However, a few candidates got confused with the distractors and selected erroneous options (a)/(b)/(c) instead of (d).
- (4) A few of the candidates erroneously selected options (b) (c), (d) as they focused on the past tense 'was' instead of present tense 'is'.
- (5) Many candidates had erroneously selected option(c) that had '...rather prefer....'.
- (6) A number of candidates did not look at all the elements involved in the mode of narration change.
- (7) Many candidates selected (c) option instead of (d). The candidates were confused due to the presence of distractors.
- (8) Most of the candidates attempted this question correctly. A few candidates had selected option (b) instead of (c).

Suggestions for teachers

- Teach students to identify the base and root verbs first.
- Help the students identify the syntax of the question tag. Identify as a positive or negative sentence.
- Revise the rules for transformation of sentences. These rules must be thoroughly understood along with the logic that goes into the forming of such rules.
- Clarify the rules for Active to Passive forms and vice versa. Also by providing many examples in class, explain the difference between have/has/had.
- Teach the syntax: Remove 'too' and use 'so' and vice versa.
- Tell the students simple syntax and transformation rules – how 'Not only' should not be combined with 'and', 'also' and the here incorrect 'but is also'. Also, encourage students not to change the tense and meaning.
- Teach the syntax of 'rather.....than....'
- Tell the students where to use 'prefer' which seems to be a word that repeats the concept of 'rather' unnecessarily.
- Advise students to practise direct-indirect speech and teach them how to change the sentence according to the reporting verb.
- Teach students subject and verb agreement.
- Discuss with students the syntax of Never, Not only, Nevertheless etc. Also, where inversion is allowed and where it is incorrect as in 'Never I have...'

MARKING SCHEME

Question 5

(i)	1. selected 2. gave 3. groomed 4. followed 5. uttered/uttering 6. letting 7. hits 8. to look
(ii)	a. on b. over c. to d. in e. with f. at g. by h. since
(iii)	1. (d) Taking pity on the mouse the magician turned it into a cat. 2. (b) This work must be completed because there is a deadline. 3. (a) He fled where his pursuers could not follow him. 4. (d) Though he began late, he finished first.
(iv)	1. (c) Arun and Nikhil had climbed the mountain, hadn't they? 2. (b) The window pane has been broken by the children. 3. (d) The apples are too cheap to be good. 4. (a) Not only is she very clever but also beautiful. 5. (b) I would rather have a simple vanilla ice cream than fancy desserts. 6. (c) He asked when I intended to make the payment. 7. (d) Unless the rain stops, Mariam will not be able to do the laundry. 8. (c) Never have I seen a better movie than this.

GENERAL COMMENTS

Topics found difficult by candidates

- **Question 1 (i):** Short scripts were quite a few in some centres while other compositions were too long.
- **Question 1 (ii):** Essay related to the concept of ‘difficult task’.
- **Question 2 & 3:** Formats of Letter, Notice and e-mail.
- **Question 4, iv:** Comprehension questions requiring higher order thinking or summary writing skills.
- **Question 5 (i) & (ii):** Prepositions and phrasal verbs.
- **In General:**
 - Usage of appropriate tenses across all questions.
 - Punctuation, spelling, grammatical and syntactical errors.
 - Singular and plural mistakes.
 - Incorrect form of the tense or a combination of tenses used often.
 - Articles were not used, incorrect prepositions, conjunctions, and so on.

Concepts in which candidates got confused

- Contextual meanings of words.
- Grammar and sentence structure and syntax.
- Understanding/identifying a question as factual/text-based or analytical.

Suggestions for candidates

- Read all the questions carefully and the instructions given on the question paper.
- Thoroughly read the comprehension passage carefully and comprehend it.
- Make sure that the length of the composition should be strictly in accordance with the word limit mentioned on the question paper.
- Do division of content into paragraphs.
- Avoid the usage of long sentences running into three-four lines and without a full stop. Use shorter and simpler sentence constructions.
- Look for casual identifiers or mutually exclusive clause hints.
- Inculcate the reading habit to improve basic language skills and fluency. Read variety of books.
- Practise regularly grammar, spellings and punctuation.
- Regularly practise the combining sentences without using 'and', 'but' or 'so'.
- Do rigorous practise of answering critical and analytical questions.
- Solve competency focused practice questions, past years' ICSE board papers and specimen question papers within stipulated time.
- Follow the format of letters, notice, E-mail and precis writing as prescribed on www.cisce.org.
- Focus on the rules of correct sentence formation.
- Practise to spot errors in the statement of the question and choose the correct option in MCQs.